the concerns associated with disbanding Salwa Judum and discharging the SPOs immediately – 'we will be spared the need to immediately give the marching order to SPOs',[38] one senior official noted. Gradually, however, its strategy grew more sophisticated. Rather than proceeding with challenging and reviewing the Supreme Court's decision, the state government chose to accept and sidestep it instead.

The Chhattisgarh government filed an affidavit claiming that it had disbanded Salwa Judum and no longer used SPOs in counter-insurgency operations. Strictly speaking, this was true – or at least clever enough to avoid the charge of open defiance of the court's decision. However, it was highly misleading. Shortly after the judgement, a law was enacted establishing a Chhattisgarh Auxiliary Armed Police Force, to 'aid and assist the security forces' in maintaining order and combating Naxal violence.[39] This sounded strikingly similar to what the SPOs did before the Supreme Court's decision. The SPOs were appointed as members of this new force with effect from the date of the court's decision. This meant that the SPOs effectively retained their jobs following the decision. The state government's public justification for this new force was that its members were better paid, better trained and better equipped than SPOs – all of which was true, but which ignored the spirit of the court's concern with establishing a parallel force to undertake combat operations otherwise assigned to paramilitary forces. As Sundar said in an interview, 'The state government simply renamed the SPOs as Armed Auxiliary Forces with effect from the date of the judgement and gave them better guns.'[40]

Sundar, Guha and Sarma were alive to the state government's attempt to sidestep the decision. They filed contempt petitions in the Supreme Court, claiming the state government had complied with the decision only in name. This set off a cat-and-mouse game in which while the contempt petition awaited a full hearing, Salwa Judum regularly changed form over the years. The various avatars assumed by Salwa Judum since the Supreme Court's decision included the Jan Jagran Abhiyan, Vikas Sangharsh Samiti, Samajik Ekta Manch and Nagrik Ekta Manch.[41] All the while, the